

Positional chess

24 topics. 96 lesson pages. One repeatable way to think.

This course is for a player who knows the rules and basic tactics and wants to understand what to do in quiet positions. Read in order or click a topic below to open its PDF. Keep the files together. The examples are original constructed teaching positions, not attributed master games.

FOUNDATIONS

- 01 Evaluate, then make a plan
- 02 Improve your worst piece
- 03 Read the center
- 04 Space and restriction
- 05 Pawn breaks
- 06 Pawn tension and timing

PIECES AND ACTIVITY

- 07 Weak squares and outposts
- 08 Bishops and knights
- 09 Bishop pair and color complexes
- 10 Purposeful exchanges
- 11 Open and semi-open files
- 12 Rooks on the seventh rank

PAWN STRUCTURES

- 13 Weak pawns as targets
- 14 Pawn chains
- 15 The isolated queen pawn
- 16 Hanging pawns
- 17 The minority attack
- 18 Pawn majorities and passed pawns

RESTRAINT AND CONVERSION

- 19 Restraint and blockade
- 20 Prophylaxis and counterplay
- 21 King safety and pawn cover
- 22 The principle of two weaknesses
- 23 Static and dynamic compensation
- 24 Convert an advantage

START WITH YOUR NEXT DECISION

A useful plan fits in one sentence: Because this feature matters, I want this change, so I will consider this move. Add the opponent's best reply before committing.

How to use a lesson

1. Recognize - 5 minutes

Read the idea and inspect Model A. Before turning the page, describe the important feature and name one useful move for each side.

2. Follow - 5 minutes

Play the worked line on a board. The gold shading on the next diagram marks the last move. Read the opponent's plan and the failure condition as carefully as the main idea.

3. Decide - 6 minutes

Solve Exercise B without the answers. Write a candidate plan, a concrete opponent reply, and the position you expect afterward. Answer the changed-feature question separately.

4. Explain - 5 minutes

Compare your reasons with the answers. Several plans can be reasonable. The score measures whether you saw the relevant facts and consequences, not whether you guessed a unique engine move.

5. Retrieve - tomorrow and one week later

Repeat the exercise from memory. Then find the same feature in one of your own games and do the transfer drill.

A REALISTIC SIX-WEEK ROUTE

Study four topics each week, taking one lesson at a time. Use the remaining sessions to revisit missed exercises and analyze a slow game. If one topic is new, spend another session on it before moving on.

Keep a simple error log: position, missed fact, wrong assumption, better question. Prefer a precise entry such as "I forgot ...c5 attacks my blockader" to a vague entry such as "bad positional play."

Read the diagrams and notation

Orientation

Each diagram is shown from the side being asked to plan: White at the bottom for White-to-move examples, Black at the bottom for Black-to-move examples. Coordinates always retain their normal square names.

Pieces

K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. A move without a piece letter is a pawn move. White pieces are cream with dark outlines; Black pieces are dark.

Moves

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. exd5 means the e-pawn captures on d5. Rfd1 means the rook from the f-file moves to d1. x = capture; + = check; # = checkmate; O-O = kingside castling.

Move numbers

1. starts a white move; 1... starts a black move. Numbers restart in each constructed position. Ellipses in prose indicate a black move. A question mark in commentary identifies a flawed candidate, not part of the legal move text.

Gold squares

On the first diagram, gold marks the concept's important squares. On the worked-result diagram, gold marks the last move. Exercise diagrams have no answer markings.

FEN

The position code beneath each exercise is Forsyth-Edwards Notation. Paste it into a chess board editor to recreate the exercise. The side to move is encoded as w or b. The PDFs are sufficient for study without another app.

WHAT THE CHECKS DO AND DO NOT PROVE

All 48 starting positions and every printed sample move are checked with python-chess for legal position status and legal, canonical move notation. The lessons use illustrative branches, including explicitly labeled mistakes. They do not claim unique best moves or engine-proven evaluations.

Your thinking checklist

- ? What are the checks, captures and immediate threats for both sides?
- ? Which imbalance matters most: king safety, material, structure, activity or space?
- ? What is the opponent's most useful pawn break or piece improvement?
- ? Which of my pieces has the least useful job, and where should it go?
- ? What do I want to change, and which two or three candidate moves do that?
- ? After the opponent's strongest reply, does the intended benefit survive?
- ? After an exchange, which structure and ending will actually remain?

References and further definitions

[Chess.com - Strategy](#)

[Chess.com - Pawn structure](#)

[Chess.com - Outposts](#)

[Chess.com - Minority attack](#)

[Lichess practice - Key squares](#)

These public references were consulted for terminology. The explanations, exercises and constructed move sequences in this course are original. Consulted September 2026.

Design and artwork

The Letter-page design follows your Desktop/agent example/example.pdf: olive #789656 and cream #eff0d3 boards, dark Cburnett vector pieces, Arial, white pages and gold accents. Piece artwork by Colin M. L. Burnett, used through python-chess under GPLv2+. Artwork source and license: [python-chess SVG source](#) and [GNU GPL v2](#).